

than his rent. (Insert panic attack here, as Ariza said.)

So what about consolidating your loans? Federal Student Aid defines consolidating as “[combining] multiple federal education loans into one loan. The result is a single monthly payment instead of multiple payments.” Before you consolidate, you have to ask your student loan service provider if you qualify. The loans have to be direct federal loans—and not yet sold the way Brunson’s have been. Consolidation can make your life easier, but it can also negatively affect your credit or give you a higher interest rate than your existing loans. You may forfeit your loan forgiveness eligibility too.

It’s hard to say definitively what any one person with loans should or shouldn’t do. “If anybody ever gives you a one-size-fits-all solution, you can immediately disregard what they said and know that they don’t know what they’re talking about,” loan consolidation expert Jan Miller warned me. It’s all a mess. For example, Miller said, people in medical school graduate and ultimately have to decide if they want to go into private practice or the nonprofit sector. These decisions will influence how quickly and how much of their income can go toward paying off the loans they took out—like Adriana Ariza’s situation.

Choosing nonprofit work can qualify a person for forgiveness programs, but they should research specifically what the forgiveness numbers are before thinking they can rely on that instead of a high-paying private sector job. There’s also loan deferment, which in some circumstances means you can halt paying loans and not accrue interest like you might with a forgiveness program.

According to the Department of Education’s student loan division, you may be able to defer your loan repayments if you are:

- ° Enrolled in an approved rehabilitation training program for the disabled community
- ° Experiencing economic hardship while serving in the Peace Corps
- ° Unemployed or unable to find full-time employment
- ° A parent

But there are many more beyond these, so go to the Federal Student Aid Office website and poke around. There are also student loan forgiveness